

STEM Racing Season 9

Team Proposal Rubric

Applications close 21 August 2026

How your proposal will be scored

Every proposal is marked out of 100 across five criteria worth 20 marks each. Two members of the panel mark independently and the scores are averaged. Teams scoring 70 or above are invited to interview. The interview is a conversation, not a test.

The panel is not looking for teams who already know how to design a race car. It is looking for teams who will still be turning up in March. Honesty scores higher than polish throughout.

BAND	MARKS	WHAT IT MEANS
Exceptional	17 to 20	Specific, evidenced and thought through. The panel could picture this team at Nationals.
Strong	13 to 16	Clear and credible, with real detail. One or two areas left vague.
Developing	8 to 12	The idea is there but the answer stays general. Little evidence offered.
Limited	0 to 7	Missing, one line long, or shows the team has not understood the question.

What the marks are out of

Each of the five criteria carries 20 marks, and each is assessed from one section of the proposal form. Nothing else is scored: there are no marks for presentation, for the length of an answer, or for how many people are on your team.

HEAD OF STEM RACING

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STUDENT MENTOR

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UNSURE ABOUT ANYTHING?

Ask before you guess.

Asking is not held against you.

1. Motivation and understanding

20 MARKS

ASSESSED FROM SECTION 3 OF THE FORM

Exceptional	The team explains why <i>this</i> competition, not just any competition. Shows accurate knowledge of what a season produces: a car, an engineering portfolio, an enterprise portfolio, a pit display, a verbal presentation. Reasons are personal and specific.
Strong	Genuine enthusiasm and a broadly correct picture of the season. Some parts of the workload underestimated.
Developing	Generic enthusiasm. Describes the racing but not the documentation, judging or business side.
Limited	Thinks the competition is only about making a fast car, or cannot say what a team produces.

2. Skills and evidence

20 MARKS

ASSESSED FROM SECTION 4 OF THE FORM

Exceptional	Concrete, verifiable examples of things members have built, designed, organised or led. Skills are spread sensibly across the team rather than concentrated in one person. Optional portfolio strengthens the case.
Strong	Real examples given, though thin in one or two areas. Reasonable spread across members.
Developing	Skills listed but not evidenced. “We are good at design” with nothing behind it.
Limited	No examples, or claims that do not stand up. Overstated experience is marked down harder than admitting none.

3. Commitment and realism

20 MARKS

ASSESSED FROM SECTION 5 OF THE FORM

Exceptional	Full disclosure of other commitments and a credible plan for the peak weeks before Nationals. Clearly discussed as a team rather than one person answering for everyone.
Strong	Honest about clashes and offers a workable plan, though the peak period is treated lightly.
Developing	Claims availability without acknowledging any competing commitment. No plan for busy periods.
Limited	Cannot commit to a weekly session, or answers suggest nobody has checked with the rest of the team.

4. Teamwork and resilience

20 MARKS

ASSESSED FROM SECTION 6 OF THE FORM

Exceptional	A named way of tracking work and a specific, humane answer to a member dropping off and to a design deadlock. Shows the team expects friction and has decided in advance how to handle it.
Strong	Sensible answers with a clear decision-making route, though light on the practical mechanics.
Developing	“We would just talk about it.” No structure, no owner, no route to a decision.
Limited	Conflict treated as something that will not happen, or resolved by one member overruling the rest.

5. Enterprise and identity

20 MARKS

ASSESSED FROM SECTION 7 OF THE FORM

Exceptional	Names the kinds of organisations it would approach and articulates what a sponsor gets in return. Team identity is deliberate, with a rationale behind name, colours and tone.
Strong	A workable sponsorship approach and a defined identity, though the value offered to a sponsor is vague.
Developing	Sponsorship reduced to asking for money. Identity is a name and nothing more.
Limited	No engagement with the business side of the competition.

Before you submit

Score your own proposal against these bands first, section by section, and rewrite whichever criterion comes out lowest. A team that has marked itself honestly almost always submits a better proposal than one that has not. The same rubric is on the website, where you can score yourself as you read.

Panel scoring sheet

One sheet per proposal. Complete independently before the panel discusses the team.

TEAM	MARKER	DATE
CRITERION	MAX	AWARDED NOTE
1. Motivation and understanding	20	
2. Skills and evidence	20	
3. Commitment and realism	20	
4. Teamwork and resilience	20	
5. Enterprise and identity	20	
Total	100	
Invite to interview?	70+	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Discuss with the panel

Marking notes

Mark the answer in front of you, not the team you know. A quiet team that has written a careful, specific proposal outranks a confident one that has written a general one. Where an answer is thin, look for whether the team has understood the question before deciding the band.

Where two markers land more than four marks apart on the same criterion, discuss it before averaging.

MARKER SIGNATURE	AVERAGED TOTAL